

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 175

By Cochran

A RESOLUTION relative to free speech and civil discourse on
Tennessee's university and college campuses.

WHEREAS, America must remain the world's leader in educational advancement and opportunity as well as research greatness; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee universities play an important role in advancing America's greatness through the development of our country's future leaders and the conduct of substantive research for the country's interests; and

WHEREAS, our State has a strong and rich history of research capabilities ranging from the University of Tennessee system, Vanderbilt University, Tennessee Technological University, Austin Peay University, the University of Memphis, and Middle Tennessee State University to several HBCUs and independent universities and colleges; and

WHEREAS, the role of colleges and universities, both private and public, in partnering with government officials in the advancement of national security, civic development and planning, and other essential quality-of-life issues is vital to our country's interests; and

WHEREAS, after October 7, 2023, when Israel was brutally violated in a terrorist attack, several universities allowed disruptive actions that threatened some students' security and stifled free speech and civil discourse in a manner that was disrespectful to the exchange and hearing of diverse opinions in a safe area; and

WHEREAS, these disruptive events continued on numerous campuses across the country and created a lack of confidence among the American people about the role of American universities in the continued greatness of America; and

WHEREAS, some universities have stayed committed to the values that make America great and continued to reflect Tennessee values while advancing the fundamental right of free speech and respect and following fundamental principles that respect all opinions of the university community; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that this General Assembly urges all Tennessee universities, both public and private, to adopt essential principles such as institutional neutrality, free expression and civil discourse, and the preservation of a campus that allows all viewpoints with respect.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that this General Assembly commends Tennessee colleges and universities, such as Vanderbilt University, that have adopted these values directly into their bylaws and governing documents and urge other colleges and universities statewide to do the same.